

16TH PRESIDENT OF THE UNITED STATES Born 1809 Died 1865

Abraham Lincoln

“Government **of the people, by the people, for the people**, shall not perish from the Earth.”

ABRAHAM LINCOLN, GETTYSBURG ADDRESS, NOVEMBER 19, 1863

Abraham Lincoln grew up in Kentucky, in what was then America's wild western frontier. His father, Thomas Lincoln, was a farmer and carpenter who set his son to hard manual labor from an early age. Abraham disliked his father and his limited world of subsistence

farming. He became a lifelong believer in technological progress and financial economy as escape routes from the backwardness into which he had been born.

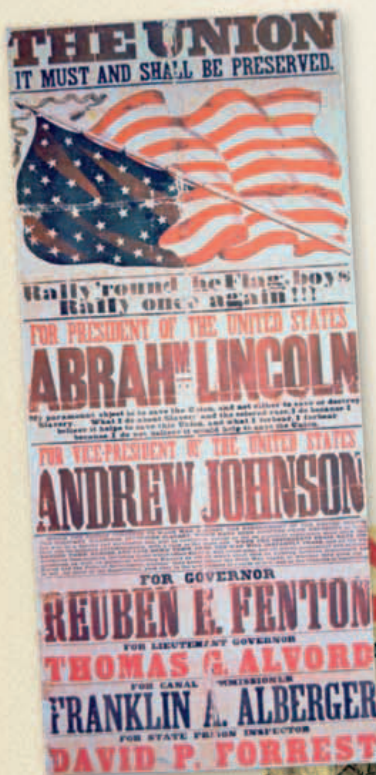
Lincoln had little schooling, but was encouraged in self-education by his stepmother Sarah. Eloquent and ambitious, by the time he was 30 he was a lawyer and, as a member of the liberal progressive Whig Party, held a seat in the Illinois House of Representatives. In higher social circles his backwoods manners were seen as rough and gauche, yet he was successful enough to persuade a plantation-owner's daughter, Mary Todd,

Wartime president

This photo-portrait of Lincoln was taken by Alexander Gardner in November 1863. It shows the president's stubborn resolve, but also reveals the sadness and strain that afflicted him as a wartime leader.

On the campaign trail

In 1858, Lincoln's public debates during the Illinois contest for the Senate attracted nationwide attention. Lincoln was at this time clean-shaven, adopting a beard in 1860 to improve his electoral chances.



CAMPAIGN BUTTON, 1864

A united front

In the presidential election of 1864, Lincoln ran with Democrat Andrew Johnson as his vice-presidential running mate. With war-weariness widespread, Lincoln's reelection was far from a foregone conclusion.



to marry him in 1842. Mary actively promoted her husband's political career, but was violently jealous and given to bouts of wild extravagance. As a couple, they did not find happiness; the death of two sons in childhood preyed on Mary's mind, while Lincoln himself was prone to fits of depression.

Elected to the US Congress in 1846, Lincoln's first foray into Washington, D.C., was not a success, so he returned to Illinois to dedicate himself to the

law and making money. It was the eruption of the slavery issue through the Kansas–Nebraska Act of 1854 that propelled him back into politics. Lincoln participated in the formation of the Republican Party to resist the spread of slavery in the expanding United States. His attitude to slavery had been formed as a child, since his family attended antislavery Baptist churches. But it was above all his personal experience of self-advancement that determined his views. Lincoln felt that his rise from humble origins showed that any free